



DELHI | Home Truths

Home Minister P. Chidambaram's visit to Srinagar was to deliver a gentle rap on the knuckles to young Chief Minister Omar Abdullah for his mishandling of the Shopian incident, in which two young women were allegedly raped and killed by security personnel. Abdullah had initially gone ahead with the police version that the women had drowned but was forced to order a judicial inquiry under public pressure. Abdullah had been unwilling to host the home minister at this embarrassing time but could do little to keep the dogged Chidambaram away. Terming the incident as "unfortunate" and admitting that there was an "avoidable delay", Chidambaram said that the intentions of the chief minister were good and that action would be taken. Abdullah, it is believed, privately admits that he has learnt the biggest lesson of his life from the incident. Chidambaram reiterated that lines of responsibility needed to be redrawn for state security. He said that ultimately the state police had to take the primary responsibility of law and order and fighting terrorism, with the Central paramilitary forces only assisting them. The army's job was defending the borders, counter-infiltration and counter-terrorism, he said. The home minister also promised to address the long-standing demand for withdrawal of the controversial Armed Forces Special Powers Act.

**CHIDAMBARAM
(RIGHT) AND
ABDULLAH IN
SRINAGAR**

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

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days passed before the police registered an FIR over the alleged rape and murder of two women by security forces in Shopian.